

SHE POWER

- Started in 2001, Mission Shakti was made a directorate in the ministry of women and child development in 2017
- It became a full-fledged department in 2021
- Annual budget: Rs 2,000 crore
- 700,000 SHGs, 7 mn members
- Block Federation under Mission Shakti comprises 1,200 to 2,500 SHGs on an average
- Loan component under Mission Shakti: Rs 3 lakh to Rs 61 lakh
- Diversification of SHG activities involve a push for mechanised and technical work. Women now operate machines for roasting millet, mixing and packaging of take home rations (THR)
- New areas: Fashion designing, apparel, gadget repair
- Efforts on to connect handicrafts made by SHGs to e-commerce platforms

ary of Rs 7,000-12,000. The group also bought a machine worth Rs 20 lakh for mechanised sieving, mixing and packaging of take home rations (THR)—fortified rations as raw ingredients or cooked food in packets that are distributed in government schemes. Some SHGs make Rs 8,00,000 a month supplying THR for public programmes.

In the farming sector, under MS, cash crops, vegetables, lemongrass and millets are being grown to ensure round-the-year income. The average income of a tribal family in the vegetables season is up by Rs 20,000-30,000. Areas unsuitable for cultivation are used for pisciculture. Government tanks under the gram panchayats (GPs) are leased out to SHGs for five years. Last year's harvest of 43,846 quintals of fish from GP tanks is an indicator of the plan's success.

Soon after being reelected in 2019, Patnaik increased the government's stake in MS by promising to buy/use goods and services worth Rs 5,000 crore from the Mission Shakti SHGs (Rs 4,000 crore has been spent in the past three years). This has helped scale down unemployment among women too. MS department officials say this has happened as unconventional avenues of livelihood, often breaking gender stereotypes, are now being pursued. Women are now involved in so-called men's jobs such as paddy procurement, public distribution system dealerships and mobile banking operations. In addition to the self-help model, as many as 15 government departments have now been directed to create jobs for women SHG members. "We are trying to push women to technology-driven work. It's heartening when these women tell us how respected they feel when people address them as 'madam'," says secretary of Mission Shakti, Sujatha Karthikeyan.

However, not everyone is an admirer of the MS schemes. "It's all big numbers on paper," says former BJP spokesperson Sajjan Sharma. "By giving women loans, they are pushing them into debt," he adds. Eminent lawyer and BJP spokesperson and Pitambar Acharya asks, "If Mission Shakti has been such a life-changing scheme for women, why are 33 million people in Odisha still dependent on subsidised rice? Instead of empowering women, they are creating a moneylender class among them—the ones responsible for facilitating loans. Loans are being given by nationalised banks. So I don't think the government alone can take the credit for its success, if any."

The criticism aside, Mission Shakti remains a fertile ground for support and bonding amongst women. When 33-year-old Mamata Swain lost her husband in a road accident, she reached out to her MS self-help groups. "I wouldn't have been able to cope with my loss had it not been for my Mission Shakti friends," she says. As the family's sole breadwinner, she earns Rs 9,000 a monthly as an electricity meter reader.

Mamata's line of work has been a singular success story. After women were trained to read electricity meters, collect charges and lodge cases of power pilferage, the power department says there is more transparency in the process and an increase in bill collections. The finance department, too, has hired many women now to work as banking agents in panchayats where there are no banks. Women banking agents now operate in around 2,500 panchayats.

There has been other stellar successes too. After months practising the preparation of snacks like cookies, namkeen and pakodas from millets, Padmalaya Mohanty and Reena Bohaider of the Shaktimayee MS federation boarded the first flight of their lives to Paris last year to participate in an international food exhibition. Their spicy savouries were an instant hit, easily outdoing many fancy confectioners.

"When the CM in a Mission Shakti programme asked women in the audience if they were getting paid regularly, a 50-plus lady told him that it had given them an identity. MS is the story of new Odisha, which is aspirational, inclusive and modern," says Karthikeyan. Another top bureaucrat agrees. Odisha's model of emancipation brings women out of their domestic cocoons and gives them an identity, he says. For millions, it's nothing short of a social revolution. ■